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## THE BOOK STOPS HERE

Why are legal reads necessary in publishing, and who has the last word? The controversy surrounding Sonia Gandhi's upcoming memoir throws these questions into sharp relief

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Maggie O'Farrell won the Women's Prize for Fiction for her 2020 book *Hamnet*. (GETTY IMAGES)

not yet know or cannot fathom; whether good or bad time will tell. The shocks ripple out towards the rest of the family back in Dublin who won't know for a while (matriarch Seraphina, eldest daughter Enda, and youngest Rose make for a compelling cast, with Eugene, already by then in his mother's belly, joining them soon after).

Tomás relocates them to an abandoned broken-down cottage in this “westernmost scrap of Europe” whose existence is “proof that everything was once something else”, that “nothing goes away”. Every family member's engagement with this transition and their relationship with the new landscape determines the course of their individual and collective lives. Like with all of O'Farrell's books, there is inevitable heartbreak, sorrow and tragedy in *Land* too.

The novel's epigraph says: “*seanchaí*: custodian of tradition, historian, reciter of ancient lore, traditional story-teller”. O'Farrell makes sure we understand the tale we are stepping into and the role her omniscient narrator will play. In its narration and non-linearity of time (sometimes going back millennia, later, ahead into the far future), the story borrows heavily from oral tradition. Around halfway, however, the magical realism suddenly disappears, only resurfacing at the very end, making the different sections feel tonally very different.

#### History, myth and memory

The author's known ability to write vividly about the natural world and how it intersects with ours is present here in *Land* as well, commanding attention even when the pace sags, even when it feels like the narrative has bitten off more than it can satisfyingly chew. This is aided by a technique familiar to O'Farrell's work, but used to great effect here given that it is above everything else a continuing story of the land; a swift movement between perspectives often within the same scene, which includes non-human points of view.

At the same time, the story unfolds what the spring has already revealed to Tomás: a good surveyor is a *seanchaí* of the land. To chronicle a document of how “a land really is, of how it has always been, of what lies beneath whatever order or disorder others might impose upon it” is both an act of honour and of resistance. And, one might add, survival. Map-making, then, is power as much as it is a responsibility to the past, present, and future. Here, it infuses the story's emotional landscape as much as it props up its (often loose and rambling) narrative structure.

The words sweeping and ambitious are overused, but both fit this third consecutive historical novel from the Women's Prize for Fiction-winning author – from Ireland to Italy to India to Canada, this is an at times unwieldy, not always convincing, family saga that tackles many themes beyond generational trauma and colonialism. At its heart, however, *Land* is a meditation on land as history, myth, and memory, and the importance of story in its preservation, even if the record is fated to remain incomplete, the story ongoing.

The reviewer is a Mumbai-based author and editor.

## In woe we sing

Imbued with a gentle sadness, Naveen Kishore's poems evoke the suffering in the world

K. Srilata

The epigraph to Naveen Kishore's luminous book of poems, *Ode to a Grieving Angel*, reads like a description of an artist's life in all its hard materiality: *somewhere between/ the despairing slopes of fingers/ hardened skin full of crevices/ covered with ink bleeding/ onto the page smudges struggling/ to swim and resist/ being dragged under...*

The poems are arranged in four cycles with a tail-end coda. At their epicentre is the archetype of the angel, the one with broken wings who grieves an accumulation of losses. The angel becomes the poet's persona, safeguarding meaning. The muse must speak in a “voice that has lost its memory”. Words must be found, the voice re-discovered in the nothingness.

The first cycle of poems brings us to a stage peopled with characters from *Macbeth*, *Hamlet* and *King Lear*, to the interplay of spotlight and shadow, to actors and audience. It offers a rich, sensory experience of theatre, of the artistry of lighting and design.

Kishore's poems have eyes:

*The curtain goes up on a dark stage. Nothing new in that. Nor the fact that it is Hamlet being staged.*

Should one decide not to read the above as lines from a prose poem, the lineation appears to enact the movement, the spilling over of the darkness from the stage onto the auditorium. “*Nothing new in/ that*” is a disruptive and abrupt sort of enjambment, the syntactic unit deliberately split. The “in” stranded at the end of the first line creates a tiny moment of suspension and the reader has to cross the line to complete the thought.

Elsewhere in the same cycle, the curtain for *Hamlet* rises to a “*lesser dark*”. It is the sort of dark to which “*your eyes may adjust*”.

#### Difficulty of speaking

What happens when language fails? This question is the focal point of the second cycle. The very alphabet is bloodless. The arrangement of words in this cycle mimics the failure of language. One word lines fill the page in staccato bursts. With a couple of exceptions, the longest a line gets is four words. The opening stanzas read:

*Blunt. Time,  
tongues 'choke'  
over  
speech  
chalk-coated  
daylight  
knocks all night long  
at eyes stitched  
shut  
blunt time  
refuses  
a strange reticence  
laps at the shores*

The lines are fragmented and breathless, the form enacting the difficulty of speaking. Kishore's use of double space between words in the



Naveen Kishore is a poet and author and the publisher of Seagull Books. (GETTY IMAGES)

same line (“*knocks/ all night long*” and “*at eyes/ stitched*”) is deliberate, indicating hesitation and disruption rather than mindful pause.

“*a strange reticence/ laps at the shores*” contains a striking shift in metaphor. We move from choking, chalk, knocking, stitching – hard, abrasive, constricting images – to the image of water lapping at the shores.

#### Performing language

In cycle three, the angel which stitches all the poems together has to endure state violence and brutality. Tried without a trial, he is sentenced to death and expelled. Simultaneously, the angel persona in heaven (there is one and that is a “she”) finds that she is no longer sheltered. There is a powerful call to “rehearse the revolution”, to subvert from below.

In the final cycle, the speaker discovers that there is no one in particular that he is speaking to, that “there never had been anyone”. In a haikusque move, he

sweeps the words off the page, stares at the letters left behind.

These are poems written in the spirit of *mono no aware* – the pathos of things, imbued with a gentle sadness. Their locus is “*the poet as a grieving being./ one who suffers as she records*”. What we take away from *Ode to a Grieving Angel* is not a failure of language but a fine and strategic performance of it, gesturing to all that we must not speak about.

The reviewer's most recent book is Footnotes to the Mahabharata (2025).



In her portrait of 19th century Ireland, *Hamnet* author Maggie O'Farrell unveils a family saga that goes beyond generational trauma and colonialism

# STORIES BENEATH OUR FEET

Anushree Nande

Maggie O'Farrell's tenth novel, *Land*, begins on a cold, windswept peninsula that stretches out into the Atlantic like “an imploring hand”. It is 1865 and Tomás and his 10-year-old son Liam work on the Ordnance Survey to map the entirety of an Ireland still unrecognisable just a decade out from the Great Famine.

O'Farrell's great-great-grandfather worked on this project around the same time. In the novel's introductory note, she wonders what it would have been like “to be recording and setting down the devastation that had occurred”.

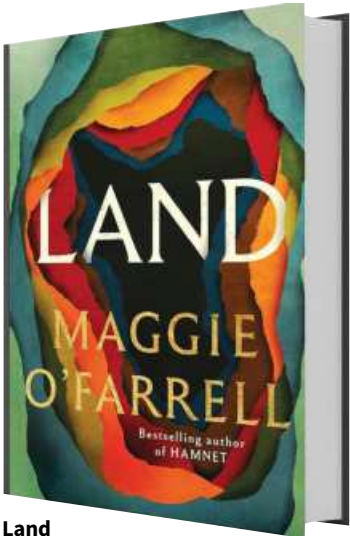
Tomás knows that the juxtaposition of his professional skills with his local language ability makes him singular, despite being classified in official accounts as a ‘labourer’. But what the redcoats from across the ocean, who have ordered an update to the old barony maps,

don't know is that he is determined that his maps will “bear an account of what happened, what was lost” even if it kills him – all the “ghost towns, the weed-lush fields, the mass graves, the workhouses, the Famine roads that led nowhere”.

#### Borrowing from oral tradition

On the fateful day we meet them, father and son stumble upon an unmarked copse of trees that

**What the redcoats from across the ocean, who have ordered an update to the old barony maps, don't know is that Tomás is determined that his maps will “bear an account of what happened, what was lost” even if it kills him – all the “ghost towns, the weed-lush fields, the mass graves, the workhouses, the Famine roads that led nowhere”**



Land  
Maggie O'Farrell  
Hachette India  
₹799

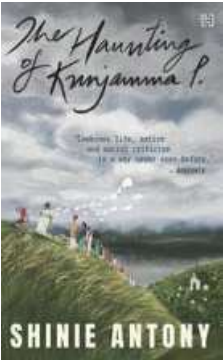
shelters an ancient spring we later learn was believed to be sacred and inhabited by spirits, giving “whatever was asked of it or whatever it was you were in need of”. Tomás drinks from it and everything changes, but it's not just him and Liam who are transformed – into what they do

## BROWSER

### The Haunting of Kunjamma P.

Shinie Antony  
Hachette India  
₹699

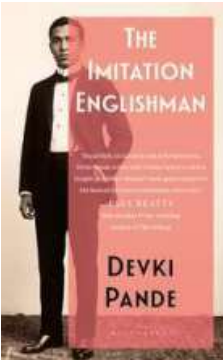
A darkly comic satire of faith, family and society, this novel set in Kerala explores the absurdity of being human. Known for her sharp take on patriarchy, Antony blends magical realism and social commentary to craft a delightfully strange tale.



### The Imitation Englishman

Devki Pande  
Bloomsbury India  
₹799

Moving between India, Germany, Britain and America, this historical fiction set during World War I is a powerful tale of adventure, friendship and the painful awakening to colonialism and racism amid India's independence struggle.



### The Most Dangerous Games

MrBeast and James Patterson  
HarperCollins  
₹899

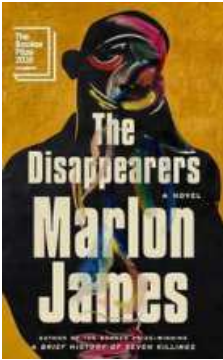
The release of this high-stakes survival thriller, co-written by YouTube star MrBeast and bestselling author Patterson, also saw the launch of a real-world contest where one reader wins \$1 million in a skill-based contest.



### The Disappearsers

Marlon James  
Riverhead Books  
₹999

An intimate portrait of queer life in 1980s Jamaica, this Booker-longlisted novel is a crime saga that spotlights human connection and the long road to acceptance “Fiction is ideally placed to bring what might be a closed-off chapter right into the open,” says James about why he wrote this book.





A view of the Meenakshi Amman temple in Madurai. (GETTY IMAGES)

# OPENING THE TEMPLE DOOR

Manuraj Shunmugasundaram writes with the flair of a journalist and maintains the rigour of an academic scholar

A.S. Panneerselvam

When we carefully create a narrative, weaving a warp of memory and mourning with a weft of remembrance and rejoicing, the fabric called history begins to make sense, clearing the layers of fog that cloud our present. This twinning is central, as most egalitarian dreams do not follow a linear path but take a sinusoidal route, where a step forward is generally followed by a couple of steps backward. The struggle for course correction brings the dream back to life.

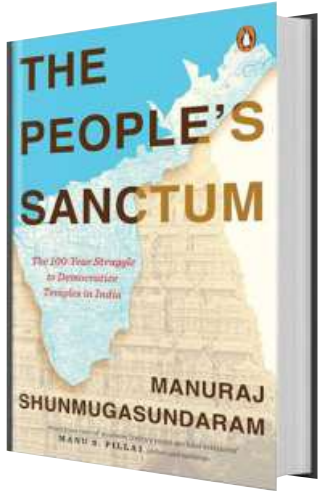
Manuraj Shunmugasundaram’s book, *The People’s Sanctum*, documents a century-long sociopolitical movement to democratise temples in India in general and in the South in particular. It was not just the sanctum; even the temple precincts were not accessible to all. This Indian journey is different from the principles that guided the West when it marched towards democracy. There, the State and Church are formally separated. Here, the decision was not to replicate that model lock, stock, and barrel. Instead, it was to examine the power dynamics that emanated from places of worship and the social inequality that flowed from them – the concentration of wealth, social clout, and the power to keep a vast section of society outside the social structure.

**Legal struggles**  
Shunmugasundaram traces the challenges faced by lawmakers and social reformers to make our society more equal. Temples cannot simultaneously be places where the privileged seek divine redemption and where the less

privileged are forbidden entry. While the southern story starts with the Vaikom Satyagraha of the 1920s, the book documents the legal struggle that dates back to the Religious Endowments Act of 1863, which dealt with the difficulty of defining who is a Hindu. Citing J.C. Ghose’s Tagore Law Lecture on Endowments in 1904, he explains the complexities of the term ‘Hindu’, which remains “difficult of definition”. The colonial administration created a negative definition. With the exception of Christians, Muslims, Parsis, or Jews, all others were to be considered Hindus. While this was a convenient tool for colonial administration, it ruptured the plural structure of the subcontinent.

When an author has more than enough historical material gleaned from archives, private papers, and political records, a dilemma arises: should they produce an encyclopaedic tome or an accessible book? Shunmugasundaram has enough historical facts that could have led to a multipart book series, but he chooses to present a birds-eye view of India’s secular character, one that imagined places of worship free from discrimination and humiliation.

**Shunmugasundaram has enough historical facts that could have led to a multipart book series, but he chooses to present a birds-eye view of India’s secular character, one that imagined places of worship free from discrimination and humiliation**



**The People’s Sanctum: The 100-Year Struggle to Democratize Temples in India**  
Manuraj Shunmugasundaram  
Penguin  
₹699

understanding the history of rights around religion and faith is of paramount importance. Shunmugasundaram tells this story with a flair of a journalist or an essayist while retaining the rigour of an academic scholar.

**Forms of resistance**  
The striking aspect of this book is that instead of creating a cleavage between Periyar’s thought and Ambedkar’s scholarship, Shunmugasundaram draws our attention to the many points of convergence between the two profound thinkers. He shows how both sought to create an inclusive public sphere in which temples had a place. The enactment of The Madras Hindu Religious Endowment Act, 1925, though not radical enough for some, opened a legal avenue to address the access to and administration of temples for those who had been excluded by

the caste system. The ground that was prepared carefully for inclusion paved the way for O.P. Ramaswamy Reddy to introduce the Temple Entry Authorisation Act in 1947. It was a commitment of the State government to “remove the disabilities imposed by customs and usage on certain classes of Hindus against entry into Hindu temples in the state”.

Enacted about five months before Independence, the Act faced two forms of resistance as the State sought to preserve the gains of hard-won social change: socio-political agitations and legal challenges. In the Madras High Court, the 1947 Act was challenged in 1956. The High Court held that nothing in the Act was “repugnant to the Constitution”. This paved the way for the State to use the two laws – the 1947 State law and the Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955, by the Union of India – to govern temple entry in the State.

The chapter ‘Courts, Customs and Constitutional Morality’ draws our attention to wilful distortions, the power of entrenched privileges, the deep-seated notion of hierarchy, and our difficulty in moving from a feudal society to a democratic one. The trajectory of *Seshammal and Others v. State of Tamil Nadu* (1972), in which the Supreme Court held that hereditary succession to the office of a temple priest is a secular practice and not an essential religious practice, tells us in an unambiguous manner that whatever progress we have made so far remains fragile and is under the constant attack. Shunmugasundaram’s book gives us a way to defend our rights.

*The writer is the Director General of the Chennai Institute of Journalism.*

## A genius in spate

Duncan Hamilton swaps the devotee’s lens for the chronicler’s, providing a detailed, sprawling portrait of Garry Sobers

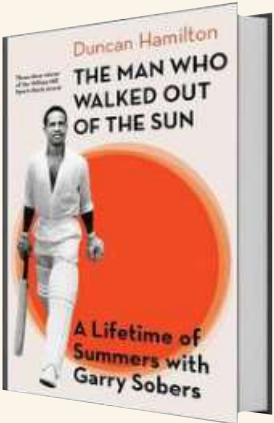
S. Ram Mahesh  
rammahesh.s@thehindu.co.in

Few obsessions are as fruitful as the one that sinks its roots in a child’s porous mind once a hero is sighted. And few heroes were as rewarding to obsess over as Garfield Sobers was.

On a cricket field, nothing seemed beyond his powers. His was not the frail, flighty genius that draws its allure from how reluctantly it gives of itself. Worshipping Sobers did not involve the seductive ferment of pining and heartbreak, aching for that elusive moment of triumphant release.

No, his was a genius in spate, swollen to bursting. Cricket poured itself into the world through Sobers. He could do everything. His strokes were made in curving-whipped lashes of a debonair blade. He swung the new ball at sharp pace and spun the old, both in left-arm orthodox fashion and wrung from the wrist. His fielding was kinetic, soft-handed, predatory.

Sobers, moreover, did it all with dazzling warmth. A young Duncan Hamilton, who first saw the West Indies cricketer on “a black-and-white set ... no bigger than a square dinner plate” in the 1960s, fell instantly in love. More than six decades of this obsessive love have culminated in *The Man Who Walked Out of the Sun*, which poignantly hit bookstores just before Sobers died in July.



**The Man Who Walked Out of the Sun: A Lifetime of Summers with Garry Sobers**  
Duncan Hamilton  
Abacus  
₹1,491

**Spectator of a dream**

The biography offers a sense of what the stellar all-rounder, the “first jet-age cricketer”, meant to generations of fans. “Even I, a know-nothing novice, recognised at first sight that Sobers was cut from the rarest of cloth,” writes Hamilton. “There was art in his hands. There was grace in his body.”

The cricket he saw emanating from the young man with “the closely cropped hair, the pencil-thin moustache and the diastema between his front teeth” transfixed Hamilton. But it was the “elan, the joie de vivre manifest in him” that engaged the boy’s undying loyalty.

In the writing of biographies, the choice of narrative aperture is defining: it determines which light, reflected off the subject, enters. The poet and novelist Philip Lindsay, in his 1951 memoir, *Don Bradman*, contends that geniuses are best viewed from a distance. “Unless one is able to know such a man intimately, it is best not to know him at all,” writes Lindsay. Far better, he insists, to be “the spectator of a dream”.

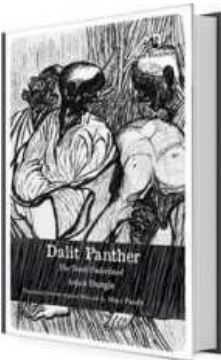
*The Man Who Walked Out of the*



Garry Sobers during a one-day match against the Duke of Norfolk’s XI at Arundel, Sussex, May 1, 1966. (THE HINDU ARCHIVES)

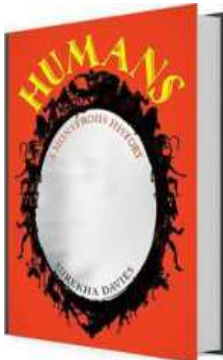
**Dalit Panther: The Truth Underlined**  
Arjun Dangle, trs. Maya Pandit  
Orient BlackSwan  
₹990

Dalit Panther, inspired by the Black Panther movement, was formed in 1972. Dangle offers a first-hand account of the rise of one of post-Ambedkarite India’s most radical movements, its literary culture, ideological debates, and internal tensions.



**Humans: A Monstrous History**  
Surekha Davies  
Westland  
₹2,977

From ancient gods and Frankenstein’s monster to E.T. and generative AI, historian Davies explores how humans have defined themselves against monsters and in the process invented ideas of race, gender, and nation.



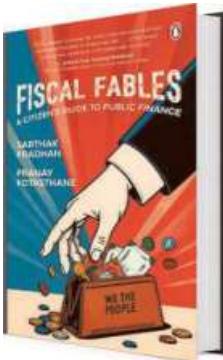
**Her Hajj Story: Travel Diaries of Women Pilgrims from Assam**  
Teresa Rehman  
Speaking Tiger  
₹699

Through 11 translated memoirs, Rehman uncovers a forgotten tradition of Hajj writing by Muslim women from Assam. Here, ordinary women become chroniclers of their own lives.



**Fiscal Fables: A Citizen’s Guide to Public Finance**  
Sarthak Pradhan, Pranay Kotasthane  
Penguin  
₹499

From north-south funding disputes to GST disagreements, the book makes sense of India’s public finances through relatable stories and everyday examples.



Authors, publishers and agents weigh in on where legal caution ends and censorship begins



I'm not saying that we need freedom of expression to degrade people or do something that's atrocious. We are talking about the right to reflect on what's going on around us.

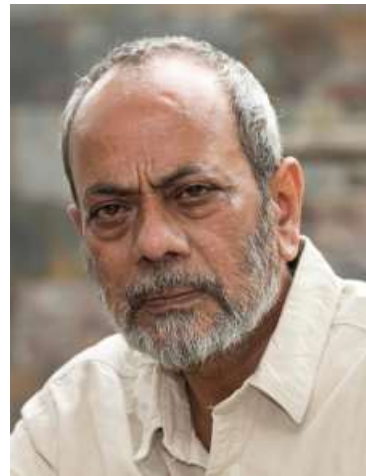
I think that publishers should be strong enough, firm enough, and willing to fight for the rights of writers. They should be willing to take risks for writers. They should be willing to allow the writers to both use imagination and creativity and, above all, integrity to stand for what they want. The minute integrity goes away from a writer, how am I different from a machine?

I think what makes a writer a writer and not an AI chatbot is that I am willing to go to jail for my opinion. I'm willing to face arrest for my opinion. I'm willing to stand by what I said. If you want only polite-ese, you can just do that kind of thing from any random LLM today.

I generally don't want to say that there's no atmosphere, no freedom to write what one wants, because I have published, time and time again, really powerful, really controversial, really strong works. I think that sometimes you do get lucky, and I have got lucky in terms of who I publish with.

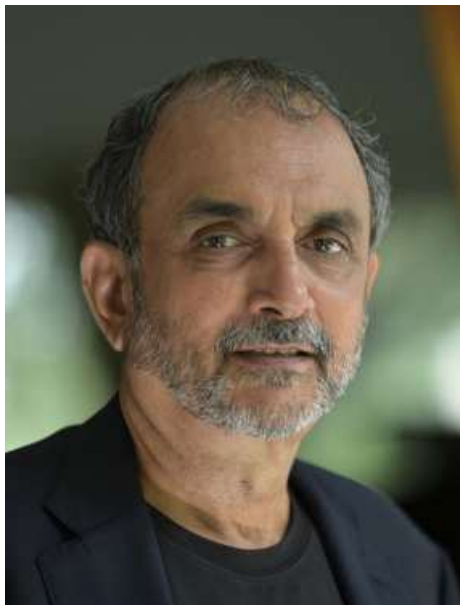
I genuinely also believe that one of the strangest conundrums that exists in publishing today is that the small presses, the independent houses [let's say, a Juggernaut or a Navayana that are individually run but are independent], have so much spine and so much courage. They stand by their writers, and they are the ones that are publishing most of my radical work. The corporates are slightly weak in the knees.

**Meena Kandasamy**  
Author



They [Penguin] signed a two-book deal with me and published the first one, *Gandhi's Assassin*, in 2022. But when I submitted the manuscript for the next one, a book on M.S. Golwalkar [after legal vetting], I was asked to remove all references to Nazi and Nazism, to Golwalkar's 1939 book, *We or Our Nationhood Defined*, and they also disputed the Home Ministry documents that I had obtained from National Archives, about an RSS camp in Pune in 1942. I also obtained Golwalkar's originally published book from the Library of U.S. Congress. Finally, I had to withdraw my book and, thankfully, Simon & Schuster India was ready to publish it. But this was very bizarre. I have published a total of five books on Hindutva [one co-authored]. I never had to face this kind of censorship attempt at any stage. I don't draw a line between freedom of expression and censorship. If you have evidence, then you must tell the story. If you are not telling the story, you are doing a disservice to society. I have not been intimidated by social, political or other extraneous pressures — in fact, by anything that falls short of a clear legal or constitutional transgression.

**Kanishka Gupta**  
Founder, Writer's Side



**Dhirendra K. Jha**  
Author of *Golwalkar: The Myth Behind the Myth*, *The Man Behind the Machine* (2024)

THINGS

BIG LITTLE



The problem with legal review reads today is that it increasingly assesses not what is legally defensible to publish, but what is virtually risk-free to publish. In India, anyone can file a case against anyone; the ability to sue says nothing about its merits. Legal review cannot therefore be reduced to asking whether someone might sue. If that is the threshold, nothing of consequence can be published. The real question is whether the material is legally actionable and, if challenged, whether the author and publisher have a sustainable defence. Freedom of expression necessarily encompasses criticism, interpretation and uncomfortable narratives. Publishers should defend that space, not allow the mere prospect of litigation to shrink it. The law does not demand risk-free literature; it demands legally defensible literature.

**Saif Mahmood**  
International lawyer and author

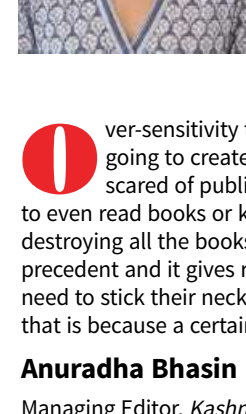


With my book on Baba Ramdev, I was reporting at the intersection of spirituality, business and politics. So, for me, the fact that my publishers were doing a serious legal read, that the manuscript was being subjected to a serious legal review, I felt protected because of it. This is something every publisher should be doing, especially for non-fiction books that impact public figures. This is not just in the interest of the public figure being written about. It is in the interest of the reporter, it is in the larger public interest that you are trying to serve through the work itself. But I think there is a very big difference between a lawyer turning around and flagging something saying, "Can you substantiate this?" versus saying "This is going to cause legal trouble". That turns into something that is no longer about informing your editors or publishers, but becomes a decision in itself.

**Priyanka Pathak-Narain**  
Author of *Godman to Tycoon: The Untold Story of Baba Ramdev* (2017)



**Saba Naqvi**  
Journalist and author



**Anuradha Bhasin**  
Managing Editor, *Kashmir Times*

Stories from the publishing world do not usually become front page news, but the controversy over the hotly anticipated Sonia Gandhi memoir, *Belonging*, has done just that. An unheralded part of the editorial process, the legal read, has become the subject of national discussion.

It appears from statements made by Penguin Random House India that some of the book's contents were flagged by the publisher's lawyers for deletion, and after some rounds of discussion, the author was not willing to remove them, and consequently the publication by Penguin in India was shelved. Although the publisher has not revealed what the deleted portions were, and has said the discussions were confidential, sources have variably suggested they concerned Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the RSS (Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh), communal riots and Chinese occupation of Indian territory.

Why are legal reads so necessary for publishers, even before the book is published? And in the process of legal review, is the lawyer playing the role of a censor? A manuscript may survive an editor, but can it survive an over-zealous lawyer? As a lawyer who frequently works with media and publishing houses, I would like to first lay out the legal landscape and then explain the mechanics of the legal read.

While our Constitution protects the freedom of speech and expression, that right is

subject to reasonable restrictions which are set out in law. Apart from civil and criminal claims for defamation, our laws contemplate a variety of offences, including broadly worded sections criminalising outraging religious feelings, causing enmity between different sections of society, and obscenity. Other more specific legislations prohibit actions such as the divulging of official secrets, the identification of juveniles in criminal matters, and even the advertising of magical remedies.

Increasingly, privacy rights are also being claimed by the subjects of reporting, and unlike in defamation actions, truth is not a defence for the violation of a subject's privacy. The wide range of possible troubles a controversial non-fiction book about current events can run into causes publishers grave concern, and that is where the lawyers come in. A legal read is a review of a manuscript before it heads to the press with an eye to avoiding any potential legal danger.

**The legal read**  
When publishers bring a manuscript for a legal read, the lawyer scans through the

It is very strange that one version of the book is published by the world but here in India, the publisher says we need to fact-check? Could they know better than Sonia Gandhi? This is an autobiography and is written by a person about their life as they see it and how they perceive the world. When a leading Indian publisher issues a statement saying the deal fell through because Gandhi needed to be fact-checked, it opens up a window, when the book comes out, for her to be attacked by a certain ecosystem in a hysterical media and social media space. Gandhi's biography is important because she's lived a dramatic life with two former prime ministers, both assassinated, and then been the longest lasting president of the Congress. Her children still lead the Congress. We should be looking at her life to understand our country's history, but right now we are looking at the little controversies. Very unfortunate.

**Rachita Taneja**  
Founder, *Sanitary Panels*, and author of *Touching Grass: A Book of Comics* (2026)

I don't understand if Penguin India is talking about a legal read or a fact-check. 'Fact-check' is a bit mystifying because every time they say it, it sort of implies that she [Sonia Gandhi] was saying something wrong and they were correcting her. In general, publishers do not question the larger arguments of the author, they only fact-check things such as dates, names, places, and so forth. The edits largely happen around what's missing, what needs better explanation. For example, we are working on a former Supreme Court judge's book, and he states that one of his problems was the extraordinary backlog of cases in our courts. Typically, it is not my job to say, "Why are you saying that? They were not backlogged." The author can have even more provocative viewpoints, but the principle remains. My job is to say, "Can you describe more of this event?" or "You have made this controversial statement, but you haven't justified yourself." I don't typically push an author on their philosophical viewpoint.

**Chiki Sarkar**

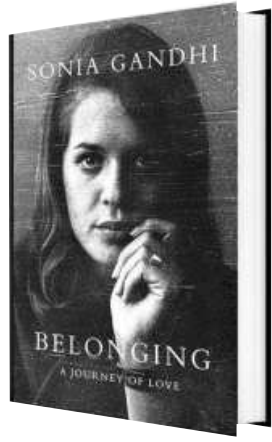
Publisher, Juggernaut Books

possibilities, both realistic and far-fetched, and goes back to the publisher with a list of passages that may have raised questions. While legal advice is conservative by its very nature, the test one adheres to is of "defensibility". It is impossible to insulate a book from litigation or prosecution completely, or even to foresee fully what some persons may find offensive, but it is possible to ensure that the contents are legally defensible. The legal read is a diagnostic and preventative step, but should not be so cautious as to turn into risk avoidance.

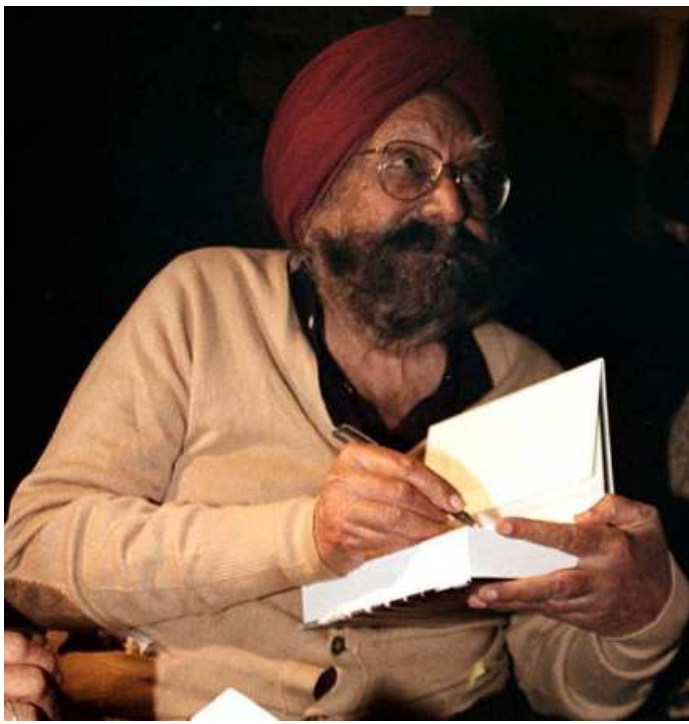
The first step in a legal read is to check line-by-line for offence. Let us consider defamation risk. The rule I use is to imagine that every person in the book is known to me, and is a friend. If a line in the manuscript tells me something

about that friend which may cause me even the mildest discomfort, I consider that statement carefully. If it is a statement of fact, what is the basis for it? Is it something that is true, or substantially true? Are there official or formal documents to support it? Were there eyewitnesses who are reliable, and if need be, can be called into a witness box? If it is a statement of opinion or judgment, is it an opinion that the author holds in good faith, on the basis of some material which is true? Naturally, the more shocking or ex-facie defamatory a statement is — for example, allegations of criminality — the harder the lawyers look at their ability to ultimately defend it in a courtroom.

Once the contentious portions have been identified, the lawyer reaches out to the



## THE BOOK STOPS HERE



(Clockwise from above) Journalist and author Khushwant Singh whose autobiography was stuck in litigation for over five years; Congress leader Sonia Gandhi whose memoir *Belonging* is at the centre of a publishing dispute; and *Shadow Armies* by Dharendra K. Jha, who was sued for defamation after the book's release. (S. SUBRAMANIAM AND PTI)

author to ask if there are supporting materials, and try to determine whether they are sufficient. Often, a handful of newspaper articles are produced — and those by themselves are not good enough, as they are hearsay evidence. On the other hand, direct eyewitness evidence, recorded interviews, correspondence from the subject, official reports, and original documents proving the allegation are all very helpful. Where the sources are insufficient, lawyers attempt a mitigatory strategy of rewriting those sentences in a way that they become defensible. Only when it is not possible to rework them at all do they recommend those portions be excised from the draft.

The legal read process therefore is a back-and-forth conversation involving the lawyer, the publisher and the author; it would be a false dichotomy to think of this as oppositional between a quisling publisher and pedantic lawyer on one hand and brave author on the other hand. After all, the author and publisher end up being equally liable in law and end up in the dock together, and as the lawyer, I have found myself defending my own risk assessment in the courtroom.

**What are the risks?**  
By the very nature of publication, the jurisdiction for an offence or for the tort of defamation can arise anywhere. Wherever a copy of the book is sold in our vast country, a reader may be offended and rush to a police station or a court. As a consequence, while books may be published in Delhi

and movies may be made in Mumbai, summons may arrive from a district court anywhere from Kashmir to Kanyakumari. Plaintiffs and complainants find jurisdictions where their political and financial muscle makes legal actions easier. In Indian law, as any experienced litigant will tell you, the process is not the punishment. For instance, when the Sanathan Sanstha sued Delhi journalist Dharendra K. Jha and his publisher Juggernaut Books for damages of ₹10 crore over his book *Shadow Armies* (2017), they filed the suit in the district court of Ponda in Goa, where they have their headquarters. The case was dismissed in 2020.

On the civil side, ex-parte injunctions (court order conservative as a rule, due to political polarisation, social media outrage, knee-jerk reactions, and an unpredictable legal system. A gulf is opening up between what the author knows and wants to say, and what they are permitted to say, and this self-censorship harms the public good.

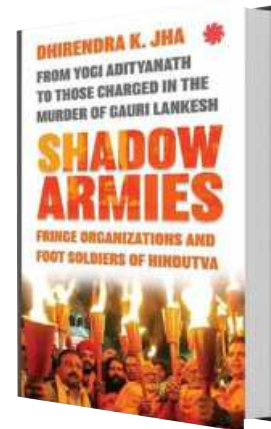
In criminal matters, the

accused parties may — depending on the exact nuance of the offence — have to appear in court, seek bail and exemptions from appearance. There is also the continuing potential for being remanded to the police, and searches and seizures. The very threat of criminal action is intimidating for most parties.

Certain publishers are more accepting of risk — adhering closer to a standard of defensibility, rather than merely "likely to cause trouble". The latter approach tries to avoid legal trouble altogether, but the cost may sometimes be muzzling the author, and depriving the public of a sharper viewpoint. The problem is that legal reads are becoming more

conservative as a rule, due to political polarisation, social media outrage, knee-jerk reactions, and an unpredictable legal system. A gulf is opening up between what the author knows and wants to say, and what they are permitted to say, and this self-censorship harms the public good.

**Drawing the line**  
So, who makes the final decision? It depends on the



contractual relationship between the author and the publisher. Authors usually provide representations and warranties that what they say is true and accurate to the best of their knowledge, and indemnify the publisher against any losses suffered if that turns out to not be the case — but those indemnities only become possible after the matter is finally determined, which may be a decade later. Typical terms in a publishing contract permit the publisher to make edits on the basis of legal advice, without the author having any say in the matter. Where the authors are big-hitters, those standard contracts may be tweaked to the author's satisfaction. But in the end, it is the publisher who is also embracing the risks of publication, and therefore has to draw the line where it sees fit.

There is an economic aspect of the publisher's risk assessment as well; a publishing giant like Penguin Random House has deep pockets and access to legal resources and media liability insurance, but a small independent publisher may not have the ability to withstand negative legal outcomes, and may be understandably more risk-averse.

While we do not yet know what the contents of Sonia Gandhi's *Belonging* were which caused the impasse between the author and Penguin India's lawyers, the reader may now have a little more context as to what takes place before such a book goes to print.

*The writer is a lawyer and author.*

### GREEN HUMOUR

**Rohan Chakravarty**

A NEW STUDY\* HAS FOUND THAT SLOTH BEARS CONTRIBUTE TO SEED DISPERSAL, HIGHLIGHTING THE UNSUNG ROLE OF OMNIVORES LIKE YOU IN RAINFOREST REGENERATION.



THIS CALLS FOR CELEBRATION!



LATER... THE COAST IS CLEAR, TROOPS! SHE PASSED OUT ON MAHUA.



Nimisha Sajayan has just delivered the performance of the year in Amazon Prime Video's new slow-burn crime drama *Babita Singh Reporting*.

As the titular police officer investigating the murder of her childhood friend Banshi (Barun Sobti), Sajayan conveys a quiet, long-suffering intelligence with her wounded eyes. She is frequently better than the film's screenplay. The pacing is uneven, and when it finally comes, the big reveal doesn't really land the way the makers would have hoped.

One thing the screenplay does get right, though, is conveying the sheer scale of Babita's balancing act.

**Justice is elsewhere**

At work she takes the blame for a media leak she wasn't involved with — just to get the leave required to attend a family function with her demanding in-laws (who make snide comments about her weight). At home, her holier-than-thou husband boasts about being a progressive champion because Babita belongs to a different (implying "lower") caste. Besides, people within the police system are always reminding Babita that the powers-that-be only made her an ASI (assistant sub-inspector) because her policeman-father died in the line of duty.

*Babita Singh Reporting* is part of a growing cohort of recent Indian films and TV shows where a female police officer is tasked with similar balancing acts — Geetika Vidya Ohlyan and Saloni Batra in *Soni* (2018), Shefali Shah and Rasika Dugal in *Delhi Crime* (2019-present), Raveena Tandon in *Aranyak* (2021),



**Lines of duty** (L-R) Bhumi Pednekar (*Daldal*); Shefali Shah (*Delhi Crime*); Shahana Goswami (*Santosh*); and (below) Nimisha Sajayan (*Babita Singh Reporting*).

### BINGE WATCH

## Madam Sir

Addressed as such, policewomen on screen fight crime but must still keep patriarchy comfortable

Sanya Malhotra in *Kathal* (2023), Sonakshi Sinha in *Dahaad* (2023), Shahana Goswami in the Indo-British film *Santosh* (2024), and Bhumi Pednekar in *Daldal* (2026).

Even if they aren't naive enough to believe in highfalutin notions of justice, these women are trying to do the right thing in their own ways. However, all of them come up against the same narrative tension — they are representatives of a patriarchal, heteronormative state. Footsolders of a system that privileges maleness, wealth, social standing and influence.

"compassionate recruitment" following the death of her policeman husband. Eventually, when Santosh tries her best to bring the killers of a Dalit girl to justice, she is heavily sabotaged by her superiors. The real perpetrators were powerful, upper-caste local leaders, and so her superior officers find a way to scapegoat an innocent Muslim man for the crime instead. In *Dahaad*, Sinha's character Anjali Meghwal changes her last name to "Bhaati" to avoid the judgments that come with a discernibly SC (scheduled caste) surname.

The other plank of this narrative tension lies in the personal. *Delhi Crime* demonstrates this via both of its major characters, DCP Vartika Chaturvedi (Shah) and ACP Neeti Singh (Dugal). Vartika's daughter Chandni wants to

move to Toronto for higher studies and leave Delhi, which she associates with objectively terrible statistics on rape and sexual assault. And she sees her mother as a major part of the system that has failed the city's women.

Meanwhile, Neeti's policeman-husband doesn't understand why she has to pull 48-hour shifts at times. Blinded by his male ego, he ironically expects her to be a fierce policewoman and a super-submissive wife at once. In *Kathal*, Malhotra's character Inspector Mahina Basore also has to ego-massage her insecure constable-husband, vastly outranked by his wife. She even turns down a promotion, insisting her husband be promoted instead.

Of all these, *Santosh* stands out. Director Sandhya Suri has the wisdom to realise that not all dichotomies can be readily resolved within the runtime. Therefore, by the end, we see Santosh preparing for a life beyond the police force. In my home state of Bihar, it isn't uncommon to see women judges, bureaucrats and police officers being addressed as "Madam Sir" by their male subordinates (a fact satirised in the Prakash Jha-Priyanka Chopra film *Jai Gangaajal*). The oxymoron "Madam Sir" communicates the impasse reached by the likes of Babita Singh who are trying their best but sometimes even the fiercest of lone wolves is worn down and defeated by the social order.

**Aditya Mani Jha** is working on his first book of non-fiction.

PERSON OF INTEREST

AAMIR AZIZ: SINGING THE BLUES AGAIN

The poet-actor on Bihar, Bukowski and his new single, a nod to his 2019 hit

Amir Aziz says he doesn't want to die in penury like fellow poet Premchand. "Poverty refuses to leave me," says the 36-year-old actor and poet. "I don't understand why." Aziz, whose blistering protest poems can make you weep or fill you with rage/ despair – Pink Floyd's Roger Waters was inspired to recite a translation of Aziz's 'Sab Yaad Rakha Jayega' ('Everything Will be Remembered') in 2020 – says he's tried everything, from acting to songwriting, to earn a living in Mumbai. "I'm not idealistic like the older poets. I've even performed in pubs and done whatever it takes," he says. But money eludes him. The impact of his published work outweighs its quantity (about half a dozen songs). YouTube removed his 2019 hit 'Achhe Din Blues' – which riffed on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's slogan during the 2014 election – for violating its terms of service. His latest, 'Dopeher Blues', is a hat tip to that hit. "It's the sequel to my very first

song which sang of morning and evening, but there was no afternoon story," says Aziz. He writes continuously in Roman Hindi on his phone. "There are a few fine days when I sit at a table and write in Urdu with a pen on paper," he adds sheepishly. Worries remain The dramatic video of Aziz's new hip-hop style single, shot in a concrete space with a Brutalist feel (don't miss the cement tape recorder), depicts a dozen or so people in factory worker uniforms and intricate balloon helmets that envelop their heads. As they play musical chairs with the Indian experience, this country devours them one by one. Now I sing in vain for strangers' funerals, a line in the song goes. It was written a few years ago but its themes are even more relevant today: honour killings; farmer suicides; Palestine; Kashmir; foot soldiers blinded by rage and orphaned of any beliefs; death and



dead dreams; the teflon bubble of privileged folks who look away from suffering. Like Aziz, we have mourned many strangers in recent years. Aziz's new release comes after a six-year hiatus on his YouTube channel, a time largely spent trying to make it as an actor in the Hindi film industry. He managed character

Censored In 2019, Amir Aziz's hit song 'Achhe Din Blues', which riffed on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's election slogan, was taken down by YouTube. (EMMANUAL YOGINI) appearances in two films by Anurag Kashyap and one by Vishal Bhardwaj, among others, but success hasn't been forthcoming. "Work in general is hard," he says. "Maybe it's difficult for people to see me as an actor." He recently discovered Charles Bukowski and says his newer work is funnier courtesy the German-American poet and novelist. If it weren't for worry about his family in Bihar, Aziz might even have dabbled in political standup comedy. Now, he plans to focus on releasing some of his unpublished songs. Resisting helplessness Near the end of 'Dopeher Blues', the poet urges his 'daughter' to sing the stories that are yet unknown to him. It is a message to children to carry on the work of being witnesses to the times. Aziz is unmarried but he uses 'daughter' because of his five nieces. The youngest of four siblings, Aziz grew up in a rural area of Patna district. His father was a Unani doctor in the health department where salaries were irregular. His mother would often say, "paisa band hai" (there's no money). "My parents invested everything in our studies, that's probably how I escaped to Delhi," he says. "If I hadn't come to Jamia Millia Islamia university, I wouldn't do what I do now. The journey from my birthplace to Jamia is usually a very

long journey that takes decades." At Jamia, as he studied to become a civil engineer, he was introduced to the guitar and Bob Dylan and he embraced both. He switched his playlist to country music that centred lyrics from Hindi songs such as the Sonu Nigam hit 'Yeh Dhokhe Pyaar Ke Dhokhe' (Bewafa Sanam, 1995). Urdu poets such as Mirza Ghalib have always been a part of Aziz's life – he says he knew their famous lines without having any memory of ever reading them. But Dylan triggered a new dream. "For the first time, I thought that I could write a song." Later, he even did a Bhojpuri version of Dylan's 'Knockin' on Heaven's Door'. Working as an engineer on construction sites opened Aziz's eyes to what he describes as one of the most exploitative workplaces. "It broke my heart," he says. "I thought, 'let's quit this job first'." In 2017, he moved to Mumbai and began life as a struggling actor. Aziz's own blues come from a sense of feeling suffocated, or the more evocative Hindi equivalent, ghutan. "Pain is alright until we are able to do something about it but not being able to do anything about your pain, only because of the broader atmosphere, is suffocating," he says. "It's almost a new culture, a state of learning how to feel helpless, and the constant fight is to resist this culture of forced helplessness." One way to do it is to sing the blues.

Priya Ramani is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.

Bob Jones

Today's deal is from a tournament in Europe. Thirteen North-South pairs reached four spades, making four or five, sometimes doubled, 12 times. The defense typically started with two rounds of hearts. Declarer ruffed he second round and led a diamond, usually won by West.

GOREN BRIDGE

Great play Both vulnerable, South deals

Declarer was threatening a cross-ruff. The defense wanted to play trumps to prevent this, but the ace and another was no good. Declarer just ran his clubs. He didn't need any more ruffs. No other suit play would fare any better. Say West played another heart. Declare would ruff in hand, ruff a diamond in dummy, and ruff the last heart from

dummy with the 10 of spades. Another diamond ruff would get him back to dummy to lead the king of spades and all would be well. At the one table where four spades was defeated, West was a player not known to us, last name Groemoller, from Germany. South led the diamond queen at trick three. Groemoller won with the king and made the brilliant shift to a low

NORTH ♠ K Q J 7 4 3 ♥ 9 5 4 2 ♦ 2 ♣ 6 5 WEST ♠ A 2 ♥ A K J 8 7 ♦ K J 4 ♣ 7 4 2 SOUTH ♠ 10 6 5 ♥ 3 ♦ Q 10 6 ♣ A K Q 10 9 3 EAST ♠ 9 8 ♥ Q 10 6 ♦ A 9 8 7 5 3 ♣ J 8

The bidding: SOUTH WEST NORTH EAST 1♣ 1♥ Dbl\* 2♥ 2♠ 3♣ 4♠ All pass \*Showed spades. 1S would have denied spades in their methods

Opening lead: Ace of ♥

spade away from his ace! He retained trump control while limiting the ruffs in declarer's hand. Four spades was usually played by North, with that powerful club suit on display in dummy. Groemoller's play was made with the club suit hidden in declarer's hand. A fine play indeed.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has September 6 ever given us?

Berty Ashley

- 1 On September 6, 1666, this overwhelming disaster was finally brought under control. After St. Paul's Cathedral was affected and much of the City of London had been in danger for four days, firefighters, soldiers and local residents demolished buildings to stop the spread. What historic event that changed the city was this?
- 2 Born on September 6, 1869, Felix Salten was an Austrian author whose most famous work inspired Walt Disney to create one of his most beloved animated films. To ensure the details of the animals were accurate, Disney even had two live fawns brought to the studio. What were the titles of the movie and the book?
- 3 Born on September 6, 1888, Joseph P. \_\_\_\_ Sr. was an American businessman and investor who made part of his fortune through liquor distribution after Prohibition ended. He had nine children, one of whom, John, became the 35th U.S. President. Robert and Ted became senators, Jean became an ambassador, and Eunice founded the Special Olympics. What is their family name?
- 4 On September 6, 1916, Clarence Saunders opened the first Piggly Wiggly store in Memphis, Tennessee. Unlike traditional grocery stores of the time, it featured self-service shopping, open shelves and shopping baskets, allowing customers to select their own



Dolores O'Riordan was a singer-songwriter who led the band 'The Cranberries'. Her unique singing, which combined rock, Celtic and yodelling and powerful lyrics brought attention to the issues in her country. (GETTY IMAGES)

- goods rather than having clerks retrieve them. This was the birth of what is now a ubiquitous shopping experience?
- 5 Born on September 6, 1919, Wilson Greatbatch was an American engineer who was working on a device to record heart sounds when he accidentally installed the wrong resistor. The resulting circuit produced rhythmic electrical pulses. This discovery led him to invent what life-saving device?
- 6 Born on September 6, 1921, Norman Joseph Woodland was a lecturer at Drexel University when he heard a supermarket executive ask whether product information could be captured
- automatically at checkout. Inspired by the idea, Woodland developed a system using lines and patterns that could be scanned electronically. What did he help invent that revolutionised retail?
- 7 Born on September 6, 1943, Roger Waters is a founding member of one of the most influential rock bands of all time. Known for his political activism and anti-war stance, he was the band's bassist, principal lyricist and a driving creative force behind some of rock's most visually iconic albums. Which band did he play for?
- 8 Born on September 6, 1971, Dolores O'Riordan was the

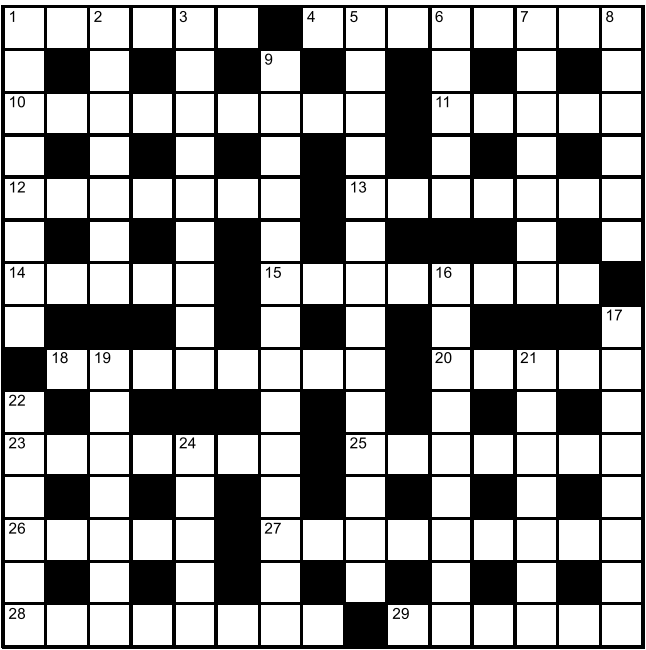
- singer-songwriter and lead vocalist of the band The Cranberries. Her distinctive voice, which incorporated rock, Celtic influences and yodelling, combined with powerful lyrics about The Troubles, brought international attention to the conflict in her homeland. Which country did she immortalise in songs such as 'Zombie'?
- 9 September 6, 1973, is the birthday of Greg Rusedski, and exactly a year later, Tim Henman was born. Both helped revive interest in British men's singles tennis after decades of relative disappointment. The zenith of British tennis, Wimbledon, was finally won in 2013 by which British player, ending a 77-year wait for a British men's singles champion?
- 10 On September 6, 1991, Russia's second-largest city officially restored its original name. It had been known as Leningrad since 1924. Founded by Tsar Peter the Great, the city was named after an apostle of Christ. Which city is this?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

- 1. The Great Fire of London
- 2. Pami
- 3. Kennedy
- 4. Supermarket
- 5. Pacemaker
- 6. Barcode
- 7. Pink Floyd
- 8. Ireland
- 9. Andy Murray
- 10. St. Petersburg

Answers

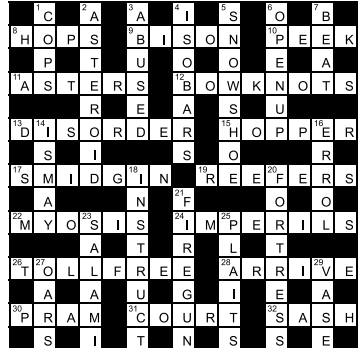
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 72 (Set by Arden)



- Across 1 Arrival at home – predator's back! (6)
- 4 Viewed separately, also therefore is a plant (8)
- 10 Return some of the oil of tropical palm holding (9)
- 11 Loud – loud not even free (5)
- 12 Half of congress is back – mostly in an Italian dumpling (7)
- 13 The noise vanishes with these Australian natives (7)
- 14 Encourage for a long time to corral the horse (3,2)
- 15 Silly old man clutched the gold and fell (8)
- 18 Trick to complete size of paper (8)
- 20 Refuse to eat a child snack (5)
- 23 Fresh air brings an Australian back in this state (7)
- 25 Brown man not allowed inside circle (7)
- 26 Monkey captures flower seller's heart (5)
- 27 Not knowing whether in church organ playing is permitted (9)
- 28 Turn girl into a piece of shipboard machinery (8)
- 29 Approves initially after department of personnel training's submission (6)

- herbs used in medicinal preparations (9)
- 5 Part of the IT revolution could perhaps be working out (5,9)
- 6 Ultimately, cotton may feel too common like synthetic material (5)
- 7 Complain about old missile (7)
- 8 A savage said to go off on the way (6)
- 9 Subject of running machines freely without copyright (5,9)
- 16 Glad about inner working in the city (9)
- 17 Fastness not opposing hair at the bottom (8)
- 19 Moronic interpretation of an alien character (7)
- 21 Straighten out prize list inside (7)
- 22 Fine on permit for undeveloped land (6)
- 24 One billed inhouse, later (5)

SOLUTION NO. 71



- Down 1 Disputed case of dog wearing fancy denim (8)
- 2 Pile on pine for some distance (7)
- 3 Formal inclusion of new plants and

# Rekindling the tryst with libraries

They should dust off their role as active spaces for discovery and learning

Vipin Benny  
vipinbenny5@gmail.com

In a small reading room run by a *grantha shala* in rural Palakkad, Kerala, part of the community library tradition that helped make the State a national model for public literacy, an old Malayalam edition of Thakazhi Sivasankara Pillai’s *Chemmeen* carries a reminder of how reading habits can change. Tucked inside the book is an issue card, the kind libraries once used to record borrowers’ names by hand. Its last entry dates from 1998. The building has not necessarily disappeared, the shelves may still be intact, and library support may continue – yet the long gap between borrowers captures a quieter question: are libraries still woven into everyday reading life as they once were?

That question matters beyond one library or one forgotten issue card. Kerala remains closely associated with India’s library movement, but the challenge facing libraries is not simply whether their buildings survive. It is whether people continue to use them, discover books through them, and regard them as an essential part of everyday life.

### The quiet crisis

India has never lacked libraries. From major institutional reading rooms to modest village panchayat libraries, the country built an extensive network of public reading spaces through the 20th century, many supported by governments and communities. The concern today, however, is less about the disappearance of library buildings than about changes in the relationship between people and physical libraries.

The national evidence is more nuanced than a simple story of universal decline. A Quantitative and Qualitative Survey of Public Libraries in India, commissioned by the Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation and conducted across the country, covered 5,140 libraries, 4,082 public-library users, and 2,035 non-users. The survey reported a substantial 10-12% growth in membership since 2014 in most libraries, excluding some State-central and town-city libraries. At the same time, 54% of the 2,035 non-users still considered public libraries relevant to their self-development needs. These findings suggest that the issue is not that Indians have simply stopped valuing libraries. Rather, patterns of use are changing, and the physical library may no longer occupy the same place in everyday life for many people.

That distinction is important. It would be misleading to describe India’s libraries as



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

experiencing a uniform collapse in footfall. What can be observed more cautiously is a gradual weakening of regular engagement in some settings, particularly where libraries face ageing collections, limited resources, changing educational habits, and competition from smartphones and short-form digital content. In some places, libraries risk becoming repositories of books rather than active spaces for discovery. School and college libraries, too, can become dominated by prescribed texts instead of encouraging exploration and reading for pleasure.

The emerging crisis, therefore, may not be a crisis of buildings at all. It is a crisis of relevance, regular engagement and the place of sustained reading in everyday life – precisely the kind of change that can remain invisible because nothing appears to be visibly breaking.

### Beyond books

The stakes go far beyond nostalgia for quiet shelves and old reading rooms. Sustained reading requires readers to remain with an argument, follow ideas across pages, and connect information over time. Research on digital reading and fragmented attention has raised important questions about whether rapid, interrupted consumption can provide the same conditions for deep comprehension as sustained engagement with longer texts. For a country seeking to strengthen critical thinking, research capacity and original ideas, the quality of attention given to information matters.

Libraries have a long-standing role as shared spaces for access to knowledge. They can provide students who cannot afford extensive private tutoring or large personal book collections with resources that will otherwise be difficult to obtain. They can also function as quiet public spaces for learners and communities who may have few comparable places for study and reflection. When access to shared reading spaces weakens, the consequences can fall disproportionately on those



**The stakes go far beyond nostalgia for quiet shelves and old reading rooms. Sustained reading requires readers to remain with an argument, follow ideas across pages, and connect information over time.**

who depend on publicly available knowledge.

There is also a subtler cultural loss. Libraries preserve regional-language literature, out-of-print works, and local histories that may not be prominent in mainstream digital discovery systems. Digital platforms have expanded access to knowledge enormously, but what appears in a search or recommendation feed is shaped by what has been digitised, indexed and made visible. If local collections are neglected, parts of India’s literary and cultural memory can gradually become harder to discover – not through censorship or disaster, but through neglect.

### A path forward

The good news is that libraries do not necessarily need reinvention so much as reimagination. Kerala’s community-library tradition and the growth of independent community libraries and reading spaces in cities such as Delhi illustrate the potential of treating libraries as living social institutions rather than storage facilities. Where libraries create reasons for people to gather, discuss and discover, they can remain relevant even in a digital age.

Simple interventions can make a difference: extending library hours to suit working people, organising book clubs and author interactions, integrating regional-language literature alongside English texts, and training librarians as curators and guides rather than merely custodians of stock registers. Technology, often blamed for changing reading habits, can also become part of the solution. Digitised catalogues, e-lending platforms and hybrid membership models can help libraries reach younger readers on their own terms, provided the physical library remains an anchor rather than an afterthought.

Schools have a particular responsibility. Children need opportunities for unstructured reading in which they can discover books out of curiosity rather than only reading to meet examination requirements. Above all, reviving reading culture requires treating libraries as essential public infrastructure, worthy of sustained policy attention alongside roads, schools and digital connectivity.

The forgotten issue card in that Palakkad reading room should not be read merely as evidence of one neglected book. It can be seen as a quiet warning – and an opportunity. India still has time to ensure that its libraries remain places where people do not merely store books, but continue to discover, question, imagine and think deeply.

## Of trials, setbacks, and victory

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When a new discovery makes headlines, it is applauded and the discoverer is rightly praised, but what usually goes unnoticed are the years of mentally demanding research behind that discovery.

The research field is an area that asks for more than just intelligence. It’s a pursuit where one reads, questions, codes, tests, fails, and tries again. A single problem can take months to solve without offering any guarantee that the efforts will produce the desired result. In computational research especially, progress is measured in lines of code written, rewritten, debugged, and tested. It’s not a place of dramatic discoveries, but of repeated trials and setbacks. It asks for one’s persistence, dedication, determination, and above all, sacrifice. Holidays are built around deadlines and conferences, family gatherings are often missed, lunch and tea breaks become shorter, Sundays, usually meant for rest, are spent at the desk, and outings are cut short because a deadline cannot wait.

It is this invisible sacrifice that rarely receives recognition. People admire the breakthroughs, but rarely acknowledge the long nights, failed attempts, and persistence. My appreciation for researchers does not come from the laboratory, but from home. My husband is a researcher and through him I have come to realise that discoveries do not happen in the moments of inspiration, but rather, in the ordinary days that call for discipline. Perhaps it’s time we celebrated not just the discoveries, but also the researchers.

### Advitya Madan

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Every summer, our family returns to our ancestral home – not for celebration but for something that has become increasingly rare in our hyperconnected lives: uninterrupted conversations with our close relatives. There is one simple rule: mobile phones and laptops stay behind. Once the screens disappear, stories return, memories resurface, and wisdom quietly finds its way into the room. We make these visits for another reason. We want our daughters to inherit something no school curriculum can teach – the perspective of those who have travelled far enough through life to know the difference between what is valuable and what merely appears so.

During one such visit, my father-in-law offered an image that has stayed with me ever since. “Imagine,” he said, “that your life is a boat sailing across a lake.” A boat needs sufficient water beneath it to move freely. If the water is too shallow, hidden rocks and the lakebed obstruct its passage. The water, he explained, represents the resources we gather through life – money, possessions, status, and security. Every boat needs enough water to remain afloat.

My daughters were

## Resisting temptation to acquire more

**A boat does not need the deepest waters on earth. It simply needs waters deep enough to sail freely**



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

quick to ask, “But what if difficult times come later? Shouldn’t we try to accumulate as much as possible?” He smiled. “Certainly. Every prudent sailor leaves a margin for uncertainty. Storms arrive without warning. So do illness, setbacks, and unforeseen responsibilities. Saving for the future is wisdom, not greed.”

### Deeper, harder

Then came the thought that transformed a simple analogy into a philosophy of life.” But beyond a point,” he said, “deeper water demands a different kind of effort.” The more we accumulate, the more

our possessions begin to possess us. Greater wealth often brings greater complexity – investments to monitor, assets to protect, decisions to make, and anxieties to manage. What begins as a search for security can quietly become a lifetime spent maintaining abundance instead of enjoying it.

His words reminded me of my own days as a young Army officer preparing for the fiercely competitive Staff College examination. Long before the Internet placed limitless information at our fingertips, we measured preparedness by the amount of study material we collected. Books, journals, notes, and photocopies filled our shelves. Looking back, many of us spent more time gathering information than absorbing it. For my first attempt, I resisted the temptation to collect more. Instead, I relied almost entirely on the handwritten notes I had prepared during the Junior Command Course. They proved sufficient. I cleared the examination in

my very first attempt.

That experience taught me a lesson whose significance I understood only years later: success often depends less on acquiring more than on making better use of what we already possess. As the conversation drew to a close, my wife shared a deceptively simple formula for happiness: the number of desires fulfilled divided by the number of desires we harbour. Most of us spend our lives trying to increase the numerator. Perhaps, wisdom lies in reducing the denominator.

Driving home that evening, I realised the conversation had never really been about money. It was about recognising the elusive moment when “enough” quietly enters our lives – and having the maturity to acknowledge it. Our age celebrates “more” as though it were a virtue in itself: more income, more information, more possessions, more recognition. Yet a meaningful life is built not merely on abundance but on balance. Ambition gives us purpose; contentment gives us peace. One without the other leaves us perpetually restless.

A boat does not need the deepest waters on earth. It simply needs waters deep enough to sail freely. Perhaps the greatest wisdom is to recognise that, for many of us, those waters have been beneath us all along.

### FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to [mag.letters@thehindu.co.in](mailto:mag.letters@thehindu.co.in) by Tuesday 3 p.m.

#### Cover story

Modern relationships appear to suffer from too much choice and too little clarity. (‘Courtship is back but something has changed’; Aug. 30) Dating apps can widen opportunities, but endless swiping, ghosting and casual connections often weaken genuine commitment. Real-life social events and community spaces may offer healthier opportunities to meet people and develop relationships at a natural pace.

M. Barathi

The illustration used for this article is impressive. Modern courtship is partially a blend of traditional values and contemporary choices. People today place greater emphasis on friendship, compatibility and individual choice. The essence of courtship may be the same but the way people experience it has certainly changed.

Ratna Naidu

#### Worthy read

There are many anti-caste reformers in India but the simplicity of Sree Narayana Guru’s teachings made him the messiah of the oppressed. (‘Beyond the saintly image’; Aug. 30) Shashi Tharoor has done a great service to humanity in writing this book.

Navin Katyal

#### A great initiative

Gallery Sumukha’s journey shows that cultural institutions need not be confined to affluent neighbourhoods. (‘Serendipity in Wilson Garden’; Aug. 30) Its growth from a modest beginning to a recognised art space reflects persistence, personal

judgement and commitment to young artists. Bengaluru should build on such initiatives by providing more accessible spaces for exhibitions and community programmes.

B.A. Neboba

#### Sheer determination

Novak Djokovic’s longevity is not merely a result of physical fitness or exceptional talent. (‘The *inat* of being Djoker’; Aug. 30) His greatest strength appears to be the stubborn refusal to give in when circumstances turn against him. His disciplined approach to sleep, nutrition, recovery and mental preparation shows that sustained excellence demands attention to every aspect of life.

Durga Arunkumar

#### Fashion expression

It was fascinating to learn about how fashion can significantly change the appearance of a person’s body. (‘Shape of things to come’; Aug. 30) The article resonated with me beyond just the topic of fashion. It prompted me to reflect on how society often establishes an ‘ideal’ body image, leading us to compare ourselves to it.

Sajina Hameed

#### Life lessons

Every child must have gone through such an innocent and naughty pilfering experience in childhood, as the author had, at her Phuphee’s house. (‘The plums I stole’; Aug. 30) But the way Phuphee cleverly handled the child with love and affection and told her that telling the truth would never get her into trouble was not only instructive, it also laid the cornerstone for character building.

Kosaraju Chandramouli



### MORE ON THE WEB

[www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page](https://www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page)

#### A modern-day illness here to stay

If loneliness is a sound, it will be the loudest the person will ever hear

Rekha Balakrishnan

#### Old-world charm of handwritten notes

Looking at them brings back memories filled with laughter, tears, candid conversations

Vidya Vasudevan

#### Of power cuts and pranks

For the young, darkness was never an inconvenience

Anulekh Babu

#### Bicycle diaries

Of an adventure on World Bicycle Day

Tathagata Nandi

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(Clockwise from below) Sabyasachi Mukherjee; a room in the designer's new Delhi flagship; a pendant necklace; and the marble funerary relief that inspired it from The Met; a Byzantine sarcophagus; and the cuff that it inspired. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



IN CONVERSATION



### Top 3 museums to visit

"I think The Met, the V&A and the Louvre. There's also the Guggenheim and so many more. But for people who want to see a larger collection of decorative arts, I think these museums are the better choices. The other museums are more niche, whether it's The Frick, the Guggenheim or even the MoMA for instance. But these are the big superstars. In India, I would say Dr. Bhau Daji Lad Museum because I love it. The Calico Museum is more fashion and textile and I love it too, but the decorative arts superstar is the Bhau Daji Lad Museum."

to send their children to better schools, eat better, travel better, consume better. With growing inflation, it is more and more important to be able to build larger profitable businesses.

**Q:** How many artisans worked on this jewellery collection and would you be highlighting them?  
**A:** I think we had about 85 to 87 artisans who worked on it. When we do shawls and saris we talk about our weavers. Here the highlight will be the storytelling about the product but the artisans all belong to Bengal.

**Q:** For a section of Instagrammers, their idea of the Byzantine Empire is going to be via you and the storytelling around these jewellery pieces on your handle. So who owns the right to reinterpret museum history?  
**A:** In this case, The Met still holds its rights. They have only said one thing to us: we do not want you to replicate what we have in the museum. We want you to take inspiration from that and create something new. Because the idea is to take objects of curiosity and create a modern interpretation with them, but still keep the spirit of the product. Everything goes through a vetting process. Only when the curatorial team and the licensing team agree together can you actually release the product.

**Q:** Could you give an example from what is on display at your new Delhi store? There is the cuff, for instance, inspired by a well-preserved Roman marble sarcophagus (see box).  
**A:** All the pieces that I've been inspired by from The Met are objects, not jewellery. So I've not taken Byzantine jewellery and recreated it. I've taken a Byzantine object, which could be a sculpture or a statue, and made that into jewellery. The people at The Met like that you don't take literal inspiration from a product..

**Q:** Is there something contradictory about taking objects in a public museum and turning their visual language into something that now costs hundreds of thousands of dollars?  
**A:** That is not really a problem because of the fact that you have to also understand how it's made. It's jewellery at the end of the day. The cost is not because of the design. The cost is because of the product. If you did it in terracotta or if you did it in steel, it would not cost that much. What makes precious jewellery precious, apart from the raw material, is if you can find an inspiration or storytelling that also gives it historical relevance.

**Q:** You often say that your jewellery at some point will belong in a museum. Is the Sabyasachi brand becoming a kind of private museum?  
**A:** I think it's a public museum more than a private museum, but one of the reasons why my products will probably find a place in the museum tomorrow is because what do museums do? They protect and preserve what's rare and what stands for a particular era of time that by nature of rarity becomes an antiquity. Craft is probably the first flag bearer of culture, but I would really like to build a house that taps into and preserves human wisdom.

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What does luxury mean to Sabyasachi Mukherjee now? Sleep and silence, says the Kolkata-based designer. The answer comes while he is discussing his new store in Mehrauli, Delhi, a 26,000 sq. ft. construction that is anything but quiet: a "mini Calcutta" of corridors, rooms, tea, music and references gathered from his own visual archive. He talks about finding quietness in the noisiest places, and about sitting in coffee shops and observing people. He talks about music that makes no sense – Alisha Chinai's 1985 hit 'Tarzan, My Tarzan' is living rent-free in my head two weeks later! And then, he talks about his pet subject: museums.

His latest project takes that obsession to The Metropolitan Museum of Art. For his new jewellery collection, which will be unveiled during New York Fashion Week on September 15, Mukherjee went into The Met's Byzantine holdings – a collection he describes as among its most impressive – and found inspiration in objects, including funerary pieces and sarcophagi. The ancient becomes wearable under his lens, and each jewel carries a QR code pointing the buyer back to its source.

Mukherjee has spent much of his career negotiating the space between India's past and the global luxury market. With The Met collaboration, that negotiation becomes unusually explicit. Excerpts from an interview:

**Question:** Why do you often look to the Byzantine Empire for inspiration?  
**Answer:** The two things that have always excited me in history are the Byzantine Empire and the Spice Route. I like people landing in different ports, in different parts of the world. New things are built with the exchange of the old and the traditional. Whether it's the Greeks, the Romans, the Far East, India, the Islamic Empire, they all found a confluence in the Byzantine world. The conflict between the Islamic Empire and Christianity led to the genesis of things, which were built with provocation and love and yes, conflict. That's why I chose that empire for inspiration, because I thought that was the most dynamic time in art.

# JEWELS OF THE TOMB

Finding inspiration in Byzantine objects for his debut collaboration with The Met, Sabyasachi turns a sarcophagus into a cuff

**Q:** Having full access to The Met, with its massive collection spanning more than 5,000 years, and its non-public storage vaults, can be overwhelming.  
**A:** The beautiful thing was that every curator took me under their wing and also showed me the unseen archives. Even if The Met has so much that the public can see, it's like the tip of the iceberg. When you speak to curators in a museum, you really learn about stories that you can't really understand when you are there as a bystander.

**Q:** Was there an Indian connection to anything that you have selected in this first collection?  
**A:** I had coins from Agra. I think they probably date back to Jahangir's time. They were actually Zodiac coins and he was one of the first people to do that because astrology was very big at that point of time. There is a necklace inspired by the coins that I found in the Islamic wing and it dates back to Jahangir in Agra.

**Q:** What does it mean for an Indian designer to interpret the collection of an American museum? Rather than just exhibit in it.

**A:** The museum happens to be American, but the product is global. India has such remarkable soft power, of craft, that it is probably one of the few countries that can take an object from a museum and reinterpret it and create it to the highest standards of craftsmanship because in many parts of the world that kind of craftsmanship doesn't exist anymore.

**Q:** In an interview with me last year, you said you were getting out of the wedding business because that was the direction globally. Do you still stand by that?  
**A:** A 100%. I didn't start off as a wedding wear designer. I started off as a ready-to-wear designer. I'm probably going back to that. I also think that to build a business entirely on weddings can become difficult because so many of your social rituals are dependent on the zeitgeist. Which keeps changing every year because the world is changing so fast. What you held as gospel five years ago is not the same anymore. Also, I think the country is becoming younger. It's important to be able to move into a non-occasion wear business because you can catch the depth and the width of it.

You can redefine the zeitgeist, which you can't always do with a wedding brand.

**Q:** Is it easy to let go of your earlier perceptions of fashion? That takes a lot of self-awareness.  
**A:** And also to let go of your ego. Sometimes, the biggest mistake is that we don't change our verticals because we are constantly living on past glory. Sometimes it also is because of

laziness and a lack of courage. When you are the king of a particular vertical, you think 'let's keep at it'. I've always said that when I become very successful in a particular vertical, it's time for change because then you also become complacent and you miss out on the bigger picture. While the wedding industry is great, I think consumption has changed.

**Q:** You have often highlighted the need to grow, to create more employment.  
**A:** You need to become more profitable so you can give people bigger bonuses. Because, you know, one thing that people don't understand is that, when you run a business, those who work for you are your family and they have needs and expenses. They want



Scan the QR code for a walkthrough of Sabyasachi's new store, on [magazine.thehindu.com](https://magazine.thehindu.com)